

Pahankanuwa Sermon #14

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

*Susukhaṃ vata jīvāma, verinesu averino; Verinesu manussesu,
vihārāma averino. Susukhaṃ vata jīvāma, āturesu anāturā;
Āturesu manussesu, viharāma anāturā. Susukhaṃ vata jīvāma,
ussukesu anussukā; Ussukesu manussesu, viharāma anussukā.*

From:

Verses 197-199 from the Sukhavagga (Chapter on Happiness) of the Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

Wishing for happiness is a common phenomenon of all beings in the entire world. The whole world is engaged in a journey in search of happiness. However, this journey in search of happiness often ends in Suffering (*Dukkha*). The reason for this is that ordinary worldlings—those worldlings whose eyes are covered by ignorance and who are bound by Craving (*Taṇhā*)—seek happiness through the wrong path. It is because they do not correctly know true happiness and the path to it that they have fallen into this state. Having fulfilled the perfections for four incalculable aeons and a hundred thousand aeons, our Buddha, the Teacher of the Three Worlds, attained Supreme Enlightenment on a Vesak full-moon day like today, in order to introduce the true path to happiness and true happiness to the worldly beings who are running in search of happiness. The Buddha, with the help of His great wisdom and great compassion, came forward on many occasions and preached the Dhamma to steer worldly beings away from seeking happiness through that wrong path, and to introduce them to true happiness. Now, these three verses we have taken as our theme, along with the story related to them, demonstrate to us how the Buddha, by virtue of His

quality as the incomparable charioteer of men to be tamed (*anuttaro purisadamma-sārathi*), employing skillful means out of great compassion, and clarifying the true nature of the Dhamma with great wisdom, brought peace to the world.

Between the city of Kapilavastu, belonging to the Sakyan clan, and the city of Koliya, belonging to the Koliyan clan, flows a river called Rohini. Constructing a dam across that river and utilizing its water, the farmers of both these cities—of both these kingdoms—engage in cultivation. During a certain drought, both parties realized that as the water was running scarce, "We cannot both carry out this cultivation; this water is sufficient for only one group." Thereupon, the two parties gathered and began to argue and dispute in order to secure the water for themselves. Having exchanged harsh words, quarreling, and hurling insults about each other's lineage, this commotion eventually reached the ears of the royal clans and the royal courts of both sides. Finally, matters escalated to the point of a great war. The kings of both sides set out for war, shouting battle cries. Precisely at dawn on that day, when the Buddha surveyed the world through the attainment of great compassion, He saw that if He did not intervene and go there, His two relative royal clans would destroy one another, resulting in a great bloodbath. Having seen this, the Buddha traveled through the air alone and sat cross-legged, suspended in mid-air above the middle of the Rohini River.

As soon as the Buddha arrived there and they saw Him, the kings of both the Sakyan and Koliyan clans cast down their weapons and paid homage to Him. The Buddha asked, "O great kings, what is the cause of this dispute?" Those kings were unable to declare with one voice what the primary cause of this war was. Because, in reality, they had been dragged into this war due to the hatred that arose after they had insulted each other's caste and lineage. Even the kings themselves did not know the underlying cause of this. Next, they stated to the Buddha, "We do not know. Perhaps the commander-in-chief might know." Then they summoned the commander-in-chief and asked him, but he too said he did not know. "Perhaps the sub-king might know," he said. Questioning in this manner, it was eventually revealed that this war was brought about by the dispute initiated by the assembly of farmers. Then the Buddha asked both parties, "O great kings, how much is this water worth?" "Venerable Sir, water is worth but little. Water is something of trifling value." "And how much are these Khattiya kings worth?" "Their value, Venerable Sir, is beyond measure; they are priceless." "Then, O great kings, why do you destroy priceless human lives for the sake of something so worthless?" When the Buddha questioned them thus, the kings had no answer to give. Thereupon, the Buddha expounded the Dhamma using the verses we have taken as our theme. Conveying the message, "All of you have made your minds extremely restless with hatred, defilements, and the search for

the fivefold sensual pleasures; yet, among such worldly people, I dwell experiencing true happiness in this manner," He uttered those verses.

'How happily indeed we live, free from hatred among those who hate!

Among hostile men, we dwell free from hatred.'

"How happily indeed we live, free from hatred among those who hate"—among hostile human beings, among the hateful beings of the world, we (meaning the Buddha and those noble ones who have calmed their defilements) dwell free from hatred. "How happily indeed we live"—extremely happily. "Sukha" means happiness. "Susukham" means extreme happiness. Experiencing happiness of the highest order, let us dwell free from hatred among a hateful world. "Among hostile men, we dwell free from hatred"—among hostile beings, we dwell free from hatred. In the same way, "How happily indeed we live, free from disease among the diseased"—among beings who are afflicted and diseased with defilements, we live extremely happily, free from disease—without that affliction of defilements. "Among diseased men, we dwell free from disease"—among such defilement-afflicted beings, we dwell free from affliction. Similarly, "How happily indeed we live, free from striving among those who strive"—among restless beings who are constantly and anxiously striving to seek the fivefold sensual pleasures, we dwell happily, free from such anxious seeking. Basing Himself on the happiness of Nibbāna that He had attained, the Buddha uttered these three verses. Having heard this, many reached the fruit of stream-entry. Moreover, that war came to an end right there.

Now, let us turn our attention to this peaceful message of solace given to us by the Buddha. Particularly, with reference to this event, we can understand how anger, rage, and hatred arise in the world. Whatever wars occur in the world, the beginning of every single one of them is the human mind. Hatred, which arises as a seed in the human mind, matures little by little. Once this becomes resentment, and finally turns into a deep-seated grudge, that defilement burns oneself while also burning others, leading beings towards destruction for a long period of time. Likewise, you, devout lay devotees, have heard the past stories regarding Ven. Devadatta. For how many aeons did that hatred, which Devadatta conceived towards the Bodhisatta in the past, persist into the future? In that manner, we must first reflect on the Impermanent (*Anicca*) nature of things in the world. Particularly this era, in this country and indeed in the entire world, is an era in which this fire of hatred, this fire of anger, is spreading everywhere. Thus, the worldly think of winning through fighting as happiness. There is a concept called "drinking the cup of victory" (celebrating triumph). Many people fight and, failing to recognize their own internal restlessness, expect calm and peace only by

crushing or killing their opponent, and then drinking to victory. But the Buddha has declared:

'Victory breeds hatred, the defeated dwells in pain;

The peaceful one dwells happily, giving up both victory and defeat.'

If someone wins a victory, it only breeds further hatred. The peaceful person dwells happily, having abandoned both victory and defeat. It is also the word of the Buddha that hatred is never appeased by hatred. This is when we understand how much destruction this thought of hatred causes throughout the world. If this is not properly treated with medicine at the very beginning, it is just like a pathogen. In a place where pathogens spread, some form of vaccination or immunization is required. Where there is no immunization, pathogens multiply dangerously and make a person sick. It is the same with this hatred. When some people lack proper loving-kindness meditation and the like to counteract this, it becomes a character trait. They always have a nature of irritability, hatred, and anger overflowing. Such a person is described in the Dhamma as "arukūpama puggala" (one like an open sore). "Aruka" means a wound or sore. When a person with an open sore goes into a crowd, whenever the crowd rubs against him slightly here and there, he gets angry because his sore gets irritated. A person with intense hatred is compared to such a wounded person. Due to that hatred, a friction-prone nature arises. He collides everywhere. He constantly collides with people and even with things. With every such collision, what is the transformation that occurs within this person's mind? Not only does that dangerous defilement of hatred manifest at that moment, but in accordance with that karma, it sends him to realms of yakkhas, ghosts, or hells for a long time in saṃsāra, bringing long-term Suffering (*Dukkha*). Furthermore, once that thought grows, it manifests verbally as harsh speech. It does not stop there. After verbal disputes, it translates into physical action, leading one even to grave unwholesome deeds like killing. In this manner, one must contemplate the disadvantageous side of hatred beforehand.

Next, the Buddha has declared five methods to appease deep-seated hatred—called *āghāta* (grudge or malice)—to dismantle resentment (*āghāta-paṭivinaya*). One, which goes without saying, is loving-kindness itself: developing the meditation on loving-kindness. Secondly, compassion is mentioned. In certain instances, compassion also helps to understand the weaknesses of one's opponent, treating it as a saṃsāric weakness, as an illness. The person who has harbored a grudge or hatred should be looked upon as a sick person, as a wounded person. Thus, by using compassion as a path and a medium, one can appease a deep-seated grudge or intense hatred that has arisen

within oneself. In other instances, equanimity. Equanimity means looking with neutrality. "This person's body and my body are both composed of these elements: earth, water, fire, and wind (*pathavī, āpo, tejo, vāyo*). Toward which part of this person am I maintaining hatred?" In that way, one endeavors to cultivate equanimity. The Buddha has declared that equanimity as well is a factor that helps to appease hatred. Also, non-attention and non-contemplation (*asati-amanasikāra*). Hatred grows because it keeps resurfacing in the mind. To eliminate this resurfacing nature, one must try not to attend to it. One must direct the mind to ignore it. It is because of the intention of revenge for the wrong done to oneself that it keeps resurfacing. Instead, one should try to forget it. Likewise, another method is shown: reflecting in accordance with the Dhamma that all beings are owners of their karma. That is, thinking of the natural law that, in accordance with karma, each person will reap the fruits and results of what they do. Now, for many, hatred arises—what they call "justified anger"—in order to "teach a lesson" to others. Thinking, "I must teach them a lesson." But they do not see the hatred within themselves; it remains hidden as a deceitful state (*vañcaka-dhamma*). Therefore, one must think: "This is a natural law of the world. If someone does wrong in accordance with karma, they will have to suffer the consequences. We should not become the instruments of that retribution." If we become the instruments of punishing them, we too will have to experience the consequences of that unwholesome deed. In this way, the Buddha has shown five ways to appease deep-seated hatred.

This is something one can experience and utilize in one's daily life. Furthermore, a monastic who was highly renowned in this dispensation for qualities like loving-kindness and compassion was the Chief Disciple, Ven. Sāriputta. On one occasion, he expounded five methods to the Sangha to appease deep-seated hatred (*āghāta-paṭivinaya*). The similes he presented are truly remarkable. He points out: suppose hatred or resentment arises in someone towards another person. That person's bodily behavior is impure—meaning his bodily behavior is very bad—but his verbal behavior is very pleasant and good, or there is no fault in his verbal behavior. Ven. Sāriputta demonstrates with a simile how one should behave when resentment arises towards such a person. Just like a monastic who wears rag-robles, while walking on a path or street, upon finding a piece of dirty cloth, presses down one end of the cloth with his foot, tears off the clean part with his hand, takes it, and goes away—in the same way, on that occasion, one should not contemplate that person's bad bodily behavior. Without thinking about the bad bodily behavior, one thinks only of the good side. One brings to the forefront the fact that his verbal behavior is good and thereby appeases one's own hatred. This is the simile given. This is not just for monastics; everyone should understand it for themselves through this simile. This means there is a person

who has both a good side and a bad side. For instance, the bad side is his bodily behavior, and the good side is his verbal behavior. If one wishes to increase one's own hatred and resentment, one is inclined to think only of that bad side. Sometimes, a minor defect as tiny as a hair can erase a virtue as grand as a mountain. One enjoys a kind of misplaced pleasure, a misplaced delight, in that thought of hatred. But it does not benefit oneself; rather, one burns. This happens because of contemplating what should not be contemplated. Thus, Ven. Sāriputta declares that, keeping that simile in mind—just as monastics who wear rag-robles do not simply discard a dirty piece of cloth but extract only what is usable from it—one should recall the good side of that person and incline one's mind toward loving-kindness and compassion. Thereby, one appeases that deep-seated hatred which yields dangerous consequences.

In the next simile, there is a person whose bodily behavior is pure, but whose verbal behavior is impure. That is, his physical deeds are good, but his speech is bad. What is the simile Ven. Sāriputta gives to appease the deep-seated hatred towards such a person? Suppose during a great drought, in the hot season, someone comes searching for water with intense thirst. There is a pond, but its water is covered with moss and water weeds. Since he must drink water, he somehow pushes aside the moss and weeds with both hands, drinks as much water as he needs, and goes on his way. Similarly, the moss there is compared to the shortcomings in that person's speech. What is shown here is that without contemplating those verbal flaws, one should take only what is good. In this manner, according to the diversity of each individual, Ven. Sāriputta has shown there a method to discipline one's feelings—a proper method of contemplation.

Thirdly, he points out: there may be a person whose bodily behavior is extremely bad and whose verbal behavior is also extremely bad. However, occasionally, from time to time, a pure and clear state of mind arises, albeit very rarely. The simile Ven. Sāriputta gives to appease hatred towards such a person is truly wondrous. Suppose during a drought, someone who is extremely thirsty goes in search of water. Along the way, there is no water anywhere except a tiny puddle of water in a cow's footprint. Seeing this, the person does not think, "Now I must bring a bucket to drink this water," or "I must scoop it up with my hands and drink it." Because doing so would stir up the mud, making it impossible to drink. Therefore, according to the situation, what does he do? He gets down on all fours like a cow and laps up that water with his tongue. This is because of his severe thirst during the drought. What does Ven. Sāriputta demonstrate through this simile? No matter how bad that person's traits are—with nothing of value in his bodily behavior and nothing of value in his verbal behavior—yet, occasionally, like a small flash of lightning in a pitch-black night, a tiny opening of goodness appears in his mind. That is enough for one to develop loving-kindness and

arouse compassion towards him. This is the lesson Ven. Sāriputta teaches. Forgetting the undesirable side, one reflects: "Ah, despite being like this, there is still this little bit of good to be taken from this person," and thereby appeases one's own hatred. All of this is done for one's own benefit. If that fire of hatred grows in one's mind, one will have to suffer grave consequences even samsāric-wise. Not only that, but even in this very life, it can escalate and eventually lead to quarrels, conflicts, and even murder. That, then, is the third simile.

Next, Ven. Sāriputta points out: there can be a person whose bodily behavior is extremely bad—nothing of value there. His verbal behavior is also bad—nothing of value there. Furthermore, not even occasionally, like a flash of lightning, does any goodness or clarity arise in his mind. In short, he is someone from whom "absolutely nothing of value can be taken." Yet, the attitude to be adopted even towards such a person is shown next. Suppose someone sees an extremely poor, sick, and helpless person traveling along a desert path. That person has no food to carry, no water to drink, no guide to show the way, no medicine. In that state, he travels along the path in a most miserable and helpless manner. How does a wise person reflect upon seeing this? "Ah, if only someone would help this helpless person and show him the way! If only someone would give him some food, some medicine, so that he would not perish but somehow survive!" In this way, he arouses a thought of compassion. Generally, when seeing such a person, those whose minds are inclined toward compassion will have such thoughts. Based on that simile, we must reflect that even if there is absolutely nothing of value to be found in the person who did wrong to us, we must still show compassion to that person. What we demonstrate through all these similes is how to apply one's mind to the simile and, through it, extract what is useful for one's own life. That is regarding the fourth type of person.

Next, fifthly, he shows: sometimes such things also happen in society. A person's bodily behavior is extremely good, and his verbal behavior is extremely good. There seems to be no fault whatsoever. Yet, for some reason, perhaps due to a personal matter, hatred arises towards him. When such hatred arises, it is very easy to appease. For this too, Ven. Sāriputta provides a simile. Just like a thirsty person searching for water during a drought who comes across a full, beautiful lake or pond, with cool shade, clear water, and shady trees all around. Just as that person, without any trouble, drinks and bathes as he wishes and rests peacefully and happily under a tree, in the same way, one should contemplate the good side of that person. Thinking, "Even though hatred has arisen in me towards this person, he possesses such excellent virtues," one should bathe in those virtues—bathe in that river of virtues—and appease one's own fire of hatred. This is what Ven. Sāriputta demonstrates.

In this manner, we have to reflect. What do we see through this? Underlying our life's path and every action we perform is the attitude we adopt toward things. "Attitude" means the way we look at something. This is something we can change; it is not permanent. We can change it. The Buddha declares that this change must be done in accordance with the Dhamma. In the Dhamma, there are two modes of contemplation: wise contemplation and unwise contemplation—or proper reflection and improper reflection. Improper contemplation is referred to in the Dhamma as **ayoniso manasikāra** (unwise attention). All defilements, and things related to them, arise because of that unwise attention (**ayoniso manasikāra**). Therefore, to be freed from them, one must practice contemplating properly. Here, what Ven. Sāriputta has shown through these similes is precisely that proper contemplation: Wise Attention (**yoniso manasikāra**). The Buddha, in short, has given permission that if a certain way of contemplating suppresses unwholesome states and arouses wholesome states, then one must contemplate in that very manner. Employing any simile or utilizing any method, one must contemplate in such a way that unwholesome states—namely greed, hatred, and delusion—and things associated with them are suppressed and eliminated, rather than allowing them to grow. For that, indeed, one has the full right to steer the mind using any simile, mental image, or wholesome thought. It is through such systematic cultivation that what we call "attitude" is formed. Now, suppose a person who does not even know what loving-kindness (**mettā**) or loving-kindness meditation is looks at the world. His perspective, his way of looking at the world, is such that he collides everywhere. He makes his entire life a mess, destroying himself and destroying others.

On the other hand, if someone begins, even gradually, to instill in their mind the truth we mentioned at the beginning of this sermon—that the desire for happiness is a natural law inherent in all living beings. Loving-kindness (**mettā**) means digesting this idea of the desire for happiness in the world into one's own mind. This mind is constantly scattered and fails to settle on a single object because of the arising of these defilements: greed, hatred, and delusion. Therefore, if we feed our mind with this universal law of the world—that everyone desires happiness—we can settle our mind within it. Thus, by framing it into a single phrase like "May they be well" or "May all beings be happy," and constantly bringing it to mind, repeatedly raising it in the mind, one's attitude is transformed. Furthermore, concentration (**samādhi**) and many other virtues develop as a result.

The Buddha has expounded many benefits of these practices. You, devout lay devotees, may have heard of the benefits experienced in daily life through loving-kindness meditation, as described in the **Mettānisamsa Sutta**. If one's mind is liberated through that loving-kindness meditation—what does it mean for the

mind to be liberated? When we say "deep-seated hatred" (resentment), the very term implies a bond—a bondage; the mind is bound. Due to some sign of irritation (*paṭigha-nimitta*) or because of a wrong done to oneself, based on the intention of revenge, the mind is constantly colliding day and night. It is like a bond—a serious bond, the bond of hatred. That is why, in saṃsāra, some go on taking revenge on each other continuously. Therefore, in place of that, we bring forward the liberation of the mind. This is called the "mind-deliverance of loving-kindness" (*mettā-cetovimutti*). When the meditation on loving-kindness is thoroughly digested in the mind, the state of having that pure mind of loving-kindness spread toward the entire world is described as the mind-deliverance of loving-kindness (*mettā-cetovimutti*). In a mind that has reached such a state of deliverance—the mind-deliverance of loving-kindness—the peace that arises yields eleven benefits in daily life, as expounded by the Buddha. One sleeps happily—attaining peaceful sleep in daily life. One wakes happily. One dreams no evil dreams. One is dear to human beings, dear to non-human beings. Even deities protect one. Also, any dangers that might come to one—dangers from poison, fire, or weapons—are often averted by the very power of that mind of loving-kindness. Furthermore, the mind quickly becomes concentrated, settled. The complexion of one's face becomes clear and serene. One dies unconfused. If one has not attained any paths and fruits, or has not realized Nibbāna, at the very least, one will be reborn in the Brahma realms. In this way, the Buddha has declared a multitude of benefits for a person who has developed that loving-kindness meditation to the level of mind-deliverance (*cetovimutti*).

Therefore, on a noble Vesak full-moon day like this, we must make a determination: to lead our lives on the right path, not much is required. Only a very slight change needs to be made. We know that even to operate a massive machine, or to get a stalled machine running, sometimes only a small pin or bolt is needed to correct the defect. Similarly, it is not a massive undertaking that helps to change one's attitude here. Sometimes it is just a single word. Installing the thought and the phrase "May they be well" into one's mind as a meditation. Meditation is not some strange thing. It is a special strength gained by repeatedly bringing to mind a wholesome thought, a wholesome object. This strength is called repetition or cultivation (*āsevana*). This means that through repeated association, one can cultivate a massive strength in one's mind. That is why, when speaking of meditation, the terms used are *āsevitā, bhāvitā, bahulikatā*—frequented, developed, and practiced abundantly. Frequently associating with the thought of loving-kindness means repeatedly raising it in the mind.

In that way, within that thought, there is a nature that liberates the mind. For the mind has been narrowed and cornered. Within the fence and gate of selfishness, the minds of worldly beings are narrowed and cornered. It is only by freeing

oneself from that selfishness that one can maintain the thought: "May others be happy." That wishing of happiness often begins with those around oneself—one's relatives, parents, children, and so forth. But one should not stop there. Next are neighbors, then neutral people, and finally even enemies—everyone. Conquering enemies in the true sense is not done through wars as mentioned earlier. Conquering the enemy is something done by appeasing that thought of hatred. The enemy is inside the mind, not the external enemy. It is the same person, but once anger arises, they become the enemy. The difference between an enemy and a friend is nothing other than one's attitude toward that person. Therefore, the moment that attitude changes, that enemy becomes a friend. That is why Buddhist scholars have stated—as a simile—if we want to walk on the ground and think of clearing all the thorns on the earth before we start walking, that will never be accomplished. Instead, when one puts on leather shoes, those thorns can do no harm to oneself. Similarly, if one thinks, "I will sleep peacefully after killing all the enemies in the world," one can never finish doing so. Killing all enemies in the world to leave only those whom one likes is something that can never succeed. Instead, what must be done is represented by the simile of putting on shoes—which stands for one's own mind. When the enemy inside one's mind is killed—for it is within one's own mind that this enemy is born—if that enemy is killed, it is as if all external enemies have been killed. In that manner, Buddhist philosophers have expounded various principles and hypotheses. It is by developing one's own mind in terms of meditation based on these that those benefits can be realized.

So it is with regard to hatred. Concerning other defilements too, we must constantly reflect in accordance with the natural law of Wise Attention (*yoniso manasikāra*) and unwise attention (*ayoniso manasikāra*). What leads us for a long time through this saṃsāra are these three root defilements: greed, hatred, and delusion. Now, greed is what the Buddha represented there as "ailment" (disease). The worldly are constantly sick. Afflicted with defilements—a state of defilement-affliction. To be freed from this defilement-affliction, one has to appease those defilements of Craving (*Taṇhā*), desire, and greed. Similarly, the worldly are in a state of striving, always restless. Due to that endless seeking, the fivefold sensual pleasures, and the intense greed for them. We can see how much destruction and how much Suffering (*Dukkha*) the worldly accumulate by running around seeking various fashions, trends, or useless things in the world. Sometimes getting into debt, they accumulate a mass of suffering simply because they have no understanding of true peace, the happiness of solace. Therefore, in accordance with the Buddha's word, we must constantly reflect, especially with loving-kindness. This era is one where the entire world is being destroyed by hatred. Hence, in daily life, one must regard a certain meditation subject

(*kammaṭṭhāna*) as one's true "workplace." To carry out daily life, we engage in various industries and works. But all of these help only to sustain the physical body—to sustain that body which we think experiences happiness. It is this mind that carries us through the entirety of saṃsāra. We leave this bodily cage behind here. But as a payment of debts for the defilements cultivated and the karma performed in the mind, beings travel in saṃsāra for a long duration.

Therefore, far greater care must be paid to our mind than the care paid to this body. This mind can be soiled very easily. Various objects in the world flow in, and there is a tendency for the mind to be disturbed either by hatred, lust, or delusion. To prevent this, some method must be employed to concentrate the mind. Now, if someone instills the thought "May they be well" into the mind the moment they wake up in the morning, and practices maintaining the mind within that thought with determination for even a few minutes, they will gradually be able to recall that thought from time to time, as the Buddha taught, in all four postures, even while engaging in other activities. Furthermore, that person will develop the power to project that thought of loving-kindness—that stream of loving-kindness thoughts—toward everyone who comes before him. A person who has attained such mind-deliverance of loving-kindness (*mettā-cetovimutti*) is indeed the one who experiences the numerous benefits of loving-kindness, just as the Buddha expounded.

Next, another helpful quality is compassion (*karuṇā*). Loving-kindness is generally directed toward beings who are like oneself. Compassion, on the other hand, is mostly for those who are suffering. Suffering can mean those who are not physically before us, or when we see someone who is injured, compassion may arise in us. But like the great compassion of the Buddha, we must reflect that all beings in this saṃsāra should be objects of compassion. Every being fallen into the suffering of saṃsāra can be an object of compassion. Thinking thus, we utilize compassion to eliminate that thought of hatred. Similarly, in daily life, to dwell happily as the Buddha taught—to dwell in extreme happiness (*susukhaṃ*)—the quality of sympathetic joy (*muditā*) is of help. These are known as the Sublime Abodes (*brahmavihāra*). Often in society, envy is prevalent. If someone appears higher than oneself, or uses more luxurious things, envy arises toward that person. There too, what exists is irritability and resentment. Instead, the entire world of beings desires happiness—everyone. One should regard their happiness as one's own happiness. That is what sympathetic joy (*muditā*) means. Even for oneself. Now, parents rejoice when their own children grow and prosper. But those same parents may harbor envy when their neighbors achieve some progress. This reveals that it occurs because of a certain defect, a flaw in the mind. Instead, one must think, just as one thinks of one's own children, that the

entire world of beings desires happiness. Thinking, "The well-being of everyone is indeed my own well-being," one cultivates the quality of sympathetic joy (*muditā*). Sympathetic joy is an extremely rare quality in society, and that is why envy and the like spread more.

Next, the same applies to equanimity (*upekkhā*). There are many things in the world that we cannot change. They are just as they are. If we try to collide with them, instead of just observing them with equanimity, it will lead to our own ruin. Why? Because each individual's lifespan and daily actions are things that have come in accordance with karma. If we can help that person to some extent through wise courses of action such as loving-kindness and compassion, we should do so. If somehow that is impossible, equanimity is what must be brought forward—neutrality. "It is that person's karma; it is something that has arisen in accordance with karma. There is nothing for me to worry about, and no way for me to interfere." Thus, one must develop equanimity toward it.

In this way, when qualities like loving-kindness, compassion, sympathetic joy, and equanimity increase in society, one can experience that noble happiness called "extreme happiness" (*susukham*) declared by the Buddha. Therefore, if we make no effort to shape our lives, our lives will be destroyed, caught up in the dangerous fires of hatred and anger spreading through society. Today, through various media, all day long we hear objects that provoke hatred, anger, and resentment. When hearing and seeing these, if one can develop a certain attitude, a strength of attitude, such that ignorance does not arise within the mind, then that person can live safely in society, just like walking with shoes on in an extremely thorny region. Therefore, what helps in all of this is the development of our mind. If one disregards the mind and its power, engaging only in jobs and other mundane activities of daily life, and thinks that is sufficient, one's destruction is very near.

A Buddha appears in the world precisely to show the noble nature of this human mind—to show to what an exalted state it can be elevated. In this dispensation, those who attained Arahantship and were worshipped even by deities and Brahmas were sometimes those marginalized in society, considered to be of the lowest caste, or those who had lived as extremely violent bandits like Angulimala, or those who had been engaged in various kinds of misconduct. All of them became recipients of the Buddha's great compassion. Through the help of His great compassion, and by virtue of the skillful means He employed based on His great wisdom, the defilements in their minds were removed—those temporarily obscuring defilements were discarded, and the strength of their samsāric training emerged, allowing them to attain that state of Arahantship. The Buddha cannot bestow Nibbāna upon someone who does not possess the capacity for it. It is by

bringing to light, training, and bringing to maturity the strength that the person has developed throughout saṃsāra that He elevates someone to noble states such as Arahantship.

Therefore, each of us must reflect: in this saṃsāra, there may be countless meritorious deeds and good things we have performed. They remain buried, like glowing embers beneath ashes. They do not emerge on their own. The method of bringing them to light is indeed meditation—accustoming the mind to meditation. Therefore, on such a valuable full-moon day, we must make a determination. It is not correct to regard these subtle things as something that most people in the world seek and see. Some people think that meditation, or taking an interest in these sermons and meditation, is only for those who have reached old age and are contemplating the next life. This is a mistaken view. A concentrated mind provides the strength to find solutions to a multitude of problems that arise in daily life—even in a very short time. Especially in a mind prepared by the Sublime Abodes (*brahmavihāra*) of loving-kindness, compassion, sympathetic joy, and equanimity, the power of decision-making is extremely strong. Such a mind is essential for making pure, clear decisions. The reason for the occurrence of wars and conflicts throughout the world today is indeed that undeveloped mind. What the worldly do in the name of "developing the mind" is either learning and studying, or applying the mind to machines, technology, and science. Through those, the mind acquires a certain expertise in mundane science, but a true systematic cultivation of the mind—the real "development" called meditation—does not occur. Instead, complex traits in the mind, like cunningness and deceit, grow in a scattered manner. This thing called the mind goes hand in hand with the heart. No mind arises free from the thoughts generated in this heart. Therefore, some purification of that heart must be done through these meditation methods of loving-kindness and the like. Otherwise, that person becomes subjected to intellectualism, cunningness, and deceitful states (*vañcaka-dhamma*), and instead of developing his mind, he drives it to extremist conditions. Under the guise of cleverness, various unwholesome and sinful deeds are presented as good things.

You, devout lay devotees, are well aware of the various types of wrong livelihood (*micchā-ājīva*) that have emerged on the stage of society today. Now, if we consider why people are unable to protect the precept of livelihood (*ājīva*) they have undertaken at this moment, it is because they have abandoned righteous ways in various manners and are exerting themselves excessively over the economy. Due to those unwholesome thoughts (*aniṭṭha-vitakka*), they forget the unwholesome aspect of sinful deeds, and instead, regard happiness in daily life as economic progress. This is what has come to the forefront of society today. The Buddha has spoken of the "happiness of blamelessness" (*anavajja-sukha*)—

the daily happiness one derives from a blameless life, where one's own mind does not blame oneself. The Buddha has pointed out four fears: the fear of self-reproach (*attāṇvāda-bhaya*), the fear of reproach by others (*parānuvāda-bhaya*), the fear of punishment (*daṇḍa-bhaya*), and the fear of a bad destination (*duggati-bhaya*). These fears represent dangers—there are four dangers for worldly beings. The fear of self-reproach means one's own mind blames oneself. No matter how secretly from the world one performs sinful deeds, like murder or theft, one's own mind knows it. That person cannot sleep properly. If someone shouts "Thief! Thief!" he turns around and looks. If someone shouts "Murderer!" he turns around to look in terror. Why? Because he thinks they are referring to him. To that extent, one's own mind blames oneself. Similarly, the fear of reproach by others means that once others find out about it, one has to hear insults and accusations from them. Furthermore, if caught in the web of the law, one has to undergo punishment. Even if one escapes all of these, in the end, one will have to experience those terrifying consequences called the bad destination—being born in hell and other places, being born in the four planes of misery. The Buddha's word is indeed true. All of this happens because of neglecting the mind—the true value of the mind.

Therefore, reflecting on these matters, you, devout lay devotees, must accord a major place to the meditation subject (*kammaṭṭhāna*) in your daily life on this precious Vesak full-moon day. As a start, in the morning, before setting out for your works and duties, you should think, "This meditation is my true work," and train yourself to steer your mind for at least a brief period in some meditation subject (*kammaṭṭhāna*). This is especially so with loving-kindness (*mettā*), which is highly beneficial when interacting with society. Alternatively, you could practice the recollection of the Buddha (*buddhānussati*) to increase your conviction, or meditation on foulness (*asubha*) to suppress defilements, or mindfulness of death (*maraṇasati*) which demonstrates the value of this spiritual life and trains one to act with diligence. One should start the day's activities after tranquilizing the mind for a short while in such a meditation subject. Similarly, at the end of the day, before going to bed—which is a time when the mind naturally calms down—if one generates a meditative state of mind before falling asleep, one will not suffer from troubles like dreaming evil dreams, as declared by the Buddha. One can attain great peace. In that way, for someone who begins and ends the day by placing the mind in meditation, gradually, even while maintaining the four postures of daily life, whenever the mind gets scattered, the meditation subject (*kammaṭṭhāna*) will spontaneously come to mind. Such a person will gain the ability, during travels and daily chores, to develop the mind through that meditation subject even during those wasted moments commonly called "idle time." What we mean by developing ourselves

through this Dhamma of the Buddha is not to adopt modern intellectualism, to learn and memorize what is in books, or to use them for some mundane benefit like passing exams. As the Buddha taught, we must make an effort through this meditative mind to eliminate the three root defilements—greed, hatred, and delusion—which subject beings to Suffering (*Dukkha*) in saṃsāra for a long duration.

Therefore, one must approach those who can provide such meditation subjects, receive those instructions with respect, and by steering one's mind within them, strive to attain in this very life that supreme happiness called "extreme happiness" (*susukham*) declared by the Buddha. The Buddha declares that all the happiness obtained even by deities is defeated by this nectar of Nibbāna, the happiness of Extinguishment. The happiness of Nibbāna is not a happiness obtained in some strange world or through some strange drink. It is the happiness of solace present in this mind—the solace and cooling that can be brought forth from within the mind itself. The Buddha declared that the entire world, existence (Becoming / *Bhava*), is burning. "*Sabbam ādittam*"—everything is burning. The worldly do not understand this burning. When we see moths falling into a lamp, it is clear to us that they are burning. But they do not understand it; those creatures do not realize it. Similarly, what the worldly constantly do is leap into these three fires: greed, hatred, and delusion. Due to the attractive nature of that fire, they do not realize it is a fire. Just as the entire world is burning with greed, hatred, and delusion, the Buddha declares that everything associated with our senses—the six sense bases—is burning. The eye is burning; forms are burning. The ear is burning; sounds are burning. In this manner, the Buddha has shown how every single sense organ, indeed the entire world, is burning with the fires of greed, hatred, and delusion. Thus, the place where those burnings are extinguished is what is called Nibbāna—the cooling. For that purpose, having settled the mind through a meditation such as loving-kindness, and by developing insight meditation (*vipassanā-bhāvanā*), one comprehends the three characteristics of existence declared by the Buddha—namely, Impermanent (*Anicca*), Suffering (*Dukkha*), and Not-self (*Anattā*). Consequently, through the penetration of the paths and fruits of stream-entry, once-returning, non-returning, and Arahantship, one can realize the supreme, deathless state of Nibbāna.

Therefore, Buddhas, Paccekabuddhas, and Great Arahants appear in the world precisely to introduce that happiness of appeasement—the happiness of cooling—to the world after realizing it themselves. That is the goal. That must be the goal of every Buddhist. With that goal in mind, making a firm determination today, declaring: "From this moment, I shall lead a meditative life," you, devout lay devotees, have listened to the Dhamma for about an hour—some of you having

undertaken the noble eight precepts on this precious full-moon day, and others having established themselves in the precept of livelihood-as-the-eighth. Listening to the Dhamma means lending one's ear during this time with the conviction (*saddhā*) one has developed toward the Triple Gem. Driven by that conviction, you engage in this task by arousing energy (*viriya*) that follows conviction. Conviction, energy, and along with that energy, you cultivate a certain mindfulness—the quality of *sati*—in your mind. By maintaining that very mindfulness for a considerable time, one can experience a certain concentration (*samādhi*). It is to such a concentrated mind that deep understandings of the Dhamma come in the form of wisdom (*paññā*). Therefore, we should rejoice that today we have used this opportunity to cultivate those wholesome qualities described in the Dhamma as conviction, energy, mindfulness, concentration, and wisdom (*saddhā, viriya, sati, samādhi, paññā*), which at a certain stage serve as spiritual faculties and spiritual powers to aid the realization of Nibbāna. Make a wish that the mental strength generated from this accumulated mass of merit may assist you in realizing Nibbāna through the penetration of the noble paths and fruits in this very life.

Furthermore, may the store of merit we have accumulated through both expounding and listening to the Dhamma be shared by all world beings—from the lowest Avīci hell to the highest Akanitṭha heaven—including the protective deities and Brahmas, as well as our deceased relatives who desire merit and long for Nibbāna. Having rejoiced in these merits, may they be liberated from this terrifying saṃsāric Suffering (*Dukkha*), and may they all attain solace in the supreme, deathless Nibbāna, free from all saṃsāric sufferings such as Birth (*Jāti*), aging, sickness, and death. Wishing thus, let us now share the merits by reciting these verses.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”